



This is SInC's first attempt at the framework you asked for: a complete operating proposal for Cohort 01, built from our side based on what we know of the campus, the students, and what is operationally fair. Where you have already given direction, we have built around it. Where things were open, we propose what we believe is fair and workable, flagged clearly so it is easy to react to. This is meant as a working draft, not a final document, in the spirit of the handshake and letter of intent you described.

1. The Three Objectives

Everything below is built around the three objectives you set out, unchanged from our first conversations.

1. **Real learning by doing.** Not a thesis-for-the-sake-of-thesis project. Students pick up a real problem and work on it for three months, whatever the outcome.
2. **Ventures that actually get created.** The explicit long-term goal is creating great ventures out of IIT Delhi in the next two to three years. Every structural choice below is built to compound toward this.
3. **Cross-border talent pollination.** Not every student needs to become a founder. Some may join an existing European or US startup, or work on a licensed or jointly built IP. The cohort should open these doors as much as it opens founder doors.

This is explicitly a Hacker House/Venture Lab for its first run, not a fully established accelerator. Lower friction, more exploratory, flexible terms. If this works, structure tightens in future cohorts.

2. Programme Shape

Duration

3 months.
20 September – 20 December 2026.

Cohort Size

5 to 10 ventures.

Tracks

5 pre-decided tracks
+ 1 open track.

The calendar is chosen deliberately around the academic rhythm. Starting 20 September means selection runs ahead of mid-semester exams (around 12 September), and the cohort itself loses only one week to academic distraction, around the third week of November for end-semester exams. This gives the cohort close to its maximum usable runway inside the semester.

3. Selection Process

A two-phase process designed to do two things at once: select the strongest cohort, and generate signal on the broader applicant pool that SInC can use beyond this cohort alone. The exact mechanics below are our proposed starting philosophy, not a locked process; we expect to refine the format once we see actual applicant numbers.

Phase 1 — Education and Applications

Tracks are published in a documented report. Five talks are run on campus, one per track, to walk students through the opportunity, the gap, and what building in that space would look like. Applications open alongside this.

Phase 2 — Hackathon Sprint

A one-week, hackathon-style sprint. Teams produce a hypothesis with supporting literature or validation, and an early proof of concept. Evaluated on two axes: strength of the builder, and strength of the hypothesis.

Final selection of 5 to 10 ventures is made from Phase 2. Strong builder and strong hypothesis combinations are selected directly. Where one half is strong and the other is not yet there, the team may be given a short retry window before a final call is made. Every applicant who does not make the final cohort is still recorded: strong hypotheses without the right team go into a hypothesis reserve, strong builders without the right idea go into a builder reserve. Both feed future cohorts and SInC's broader pipeline.

4. Reporting Rhythm and Underperformance

Evaluation through the cohort is track-dependent, not a single uniform bar. Established accelerator and deep-tech programmes typically separate “proof of movement” from “proof of compliance”: what counts as progress in month one for a software venture looks nothing like progress for a venture still validating core feasibility, and holding both to the same checklist produces a false read on either. We propose three parallel monitoring channels rather than one, run at different cadences depending on what each is actually meant to catch.

Channel	What it tracks and how often
SInC weekly check-in	A short, lightweight update from every team each week, owned by the assigned coordinator. Tracks whether work is genuinely moving, not whether a specific deliverable has shipped. This is the floor: missing it without communication is the only thing that escalates on its own.
Mentor review	Biweekly or monthly, depending on the mentor’s own availability and the venture’s pace. A deeper, qualitative read on direction and decision-making, not just output.
Technical or domain-specific milestone tracking	For ventures where progress is not well captured by shipped features or user feedback, for instance anything with a long build, validation, or regulatory cycle, we propose tracking maturity against a recognised staged framework (the kind used in deep-tech and R&D-heavy ventures globally) rather than forcing a software-style weekly output expectation onto something that genuinely cannot move that fast.

Within this, what counts as satisfactory progress at each monthly gate is agreed per venture at kickoff: a shipped prototype or validated pivot for a software track, a working proof of concept for an IP-assigned track, a locked hypothesis by month one and a working build by month three for the open track, or a movement up the relevant maturity scale for a venture being tracked on the third channel above.

Alongside progress, every venture submits a brief expenditure report at each gate: what was spent, against what, and a short justification for the funds requested for the following month. This is not a formality; it is what makes the reimbursement structure in Section 6 auditable and gives both SInC and you a real basis for any top-up decision, rather than asking for more money without showing what the last tranche actually went toward.

On underperformance specifically, we propose a two-step process rather than a single cutoff. A team behind on its gate is first placed in spotlight: flagged openly within the cohort, given a defined check-in plan with their coordinator, and given one full gate cycle to course-correct, in the spirit of a first cohort that should give people room to recover. If a team remains behind at the next gate with no meaningful change, it moves to scrutiny: a closer joint review by SInC and you, with the explicit possible outcomes being continued support, a change in track or team composition, or exit from the cohort. The one thing that triggers a direct move to scrutiny without a spotlight step first is disengagement, missing the weekly floor without communication, since that is a different problem from slow progress.

5. Funding Terms and Cap Table

This section is the one place we want to stay genuinely flexible. Building a rigid framework for every funding scenario before a single venture exists tends to produce rules that break the moment reality does not match the guess. The approach below leaves the actual number and structure for each venture to a proposal-and-evaluation process, while being clear on what instrument we think is right and why.

5.1 How a venture gets funded

Rather than a fixed cheque size, we propose that each venture submits a short proposal at the relevant gate: what they need, what they believe is a fair valuation or cap, and what equity they are offering for it. You evaluate this against the team, the traction shown, and your own read of the opportunity, broadly the same way any investor evaluates a real ask rather than fitting it into a pre-built band. As a working reference point, similar Indian student-focused investment programmes have written cheques in the range of roughly Rs. 10 lakh to Rs. 1 crore depending on stage and equity offered; we mention this only as context for what is realistic in this market, not as a cap or floor we are proposing to hold you to. We will work out a standard term sheet template together once we have a clearer sense of the kind of proposals coming through, rather than fixing one now.

5.2 Instrument

We propose a SAFE as the primary instrument, the same structure YC and most comparable programmes use for exactly this stage: equity is decided at the next priced round rather than negotiated upfront, which keeps things fast and avoids a valuation argument before there is anything to value.

One structure worth exploring, not something we are firmly proposing, is a tranching SAFE: rather than the full cheque at once, capital is released in smaller pieces tied to progress. As an illustration of how this could look: a small kickoff tranche at entry for build costs if needed, a further tranche around month one for teams showing early validation and a defined build plan, a larger tranche around month two for teams with a working prototype or real user and customer discovery, and the final top-up or pre-seed conversation reserved for Demo Day for the strongest ventures. We are open to discussing whether this or a single upfront SAFE makes more sense once we see the kind of proposals coming in.

5.3 Non-dilutive option

A non-dilutive grant pathway is worth exploring as an option, a non-dilutive grant, maybe not something we are proposing as a firm feature of Cohort 01. Grants typically make sense for social-impact or public-good focused initiatives run

by governments or larger funds; whether something similar is feasible or appropriate here, given this is investor capital rather than philanthropic capital, is genuinely open and worth a direct conversation rather than us assuming it into the structure.

5.4 Pre-seed and follow-on

For ventures you choose to back further at or after Demo Day, we propose the overall structure broadly mirror how YC and comparable programmes handle their own follow-on terms, an approach we are happy to align on in more detail directly rather than fixing every number in this document. The exact percentage and terms in each case remain at your discretion, since they should reasonably reflect the specifics of that venture and round.

6. Build and Operational Costs

Every number below is broken down to what it actually buys, in rupees throughout. This is a working proposal, open to revision once we have firmer inputs from FITT and from actual usage once the cohort is running.

6.1 Per-venture build budget

We propose a fixed monthly cap of Rs. 40,000–43,000 per venture, reimbursable against actual bills. Indicative breakdown at the higher end of typical usage:

Item	Monthly cost
Claude Pro / equivalent AI tooling	Rs. 2,000 per student $\times$ 3 active builders $\approx$ Rs. 6,000
API usage (LLM calls, third-party APIs)	Rs. 17,000–22,000, scales with track; agent-heavy or data-heavy builds run higher
Cloud hosting (AWS / GCP / Vercel)	Rs. 8,500–11,500 on starter to mid tiers
Domain and miscellaneous tooling	Rs. 1,700–2,600
Incorporation, when due (one-time, in the month it occurs)	Rs. 13,000–17,500, equivalent to the typical Indian Pvt. Ltd. or LLP filing cost
Total	Rs. 39,000–48,500, capped at Rs. 40,000–43,000

This cap is fixed for the duration of the cohort. Any venture that expects to exceed it must flag this and get approval before the spend is incurred, not after. Every rupee spent under this budget is tracked against an itemised bill and reconciled monthly, the same audit trail as the rest of this proposal. Folding incorporation cost into this same monthly cap, rather than treating it as a separate negotiation, means a founder who pays for filing out of pocket in a given month is reimbursed through this budget exactly like any other build cost.

6.2 SInC operational costs

This is the budget for SInC to run the cohort’s community and programming layer through the three months: founder meets, industry sessions, documentation, and the cohort dinners that keep the group feeling like one cohort rather than several disconnected teams. We have built this up from a per-session and per-head basis so each line is checkable against a real unit cost, with a working buffer on top.

Item	Unit basis	Monthly cost
Biweekly founder meets	2 sessions/month $\times$ $\sim$ 25 attendees $\times$ Rs. 150/head (tea and light snacks, Delhi catering rates for this scale)	Rs. 7,500
Industry sessions	1–2 sessions/month; local hospitality and light refreshments for $\sim$ 25 attendees, no speaker honorarium	Rs. 8,000
Cohort dinner	1 dinner/month $\times$ $\sim$ 25 (cohort plus core team) $\times$ Rs. 400/head (sit-down veg meal, Delhi per-plate rate for this group size)	Rs. 10,000
Documentation and content	Cohort website hosting, basic design tools, and content support for tracking and social proof material	Rs. 6,000
Printing, signage, and logistics	Track reports, session signage, miscellaneous on-the-day costs	Rs. 4,000
Working and contingency buffer	Covers larger-than-expected attendance, last-minute changes, and miscellaneous programme costs not itemised above	Rs. 14,500
Total		Rs. 50,000 per month

This budget is for SInC’s own use in running the cohort, distinct from the founder fellowship in 6.4 and the per-venture

build budget in 6.1. Unutilised amounts in any given month are returned or adjusted into the following month. We will share an expenditure report after every event through the three months of the cohort, so spend against this breakdown is visible as it happens rather than reconciled only at the end.

6.3 Selection hackathon budget

We propose Rs. 50,000–60,000 as the core budget for the selection hackathon, covering prizes, snacks, and credits for participants during the sprint. We propose raising any amount beyond this through sponsors rather than the cohort budget itself. For reference, this year’s Anthropic-partnered hackathon on campus ran a prize pool of Rs. 95,000 alone; sponsorship has already proven to be a realistic and scalable way to fund an event at this scale, and also gives us a natural reason to bring in partners, such as cloud or tool credit sponsors, who may stay useful to the cohort beyond the selection event itself.

6.4 Founder fellowship

We propose a fellowship of Rs. 20,000 per month for every selected student in the cohort, paid independent of equity or investment terms. This mirrors how comparable Indian founder-support programmes structure cash support, equity-free and separate from any capital tied to the venture itself; the NIDHI-EIR programme run by the Department of Science and Technology, for instance, provides idea-stage founders a stipend of up to Rs. 30,000 per month on a similar basis. Rs. 20,000 sits below that as a deliberately conservative starting figure for a first cohort, and also matches what students themselves told us was meaningful in our interviews ahead of this proposal.

6.5 Office space at the Research and Innovation Park

This is a nice-to-have, not a requirement. Students continue to live in their existing hostel accommodation through the cohort, and the cohort runs perfectly well without any dedicated office space. We are exploring whether a small amount of shared office or co-working space at FITT’s Research and Innovation Park is available, purely as an upgrade to the working experience, not as something the cohort depends on.

FITT’s published rate for incubated entities at the Research and Innovation Park is Rs. 25 per sq. ft. per month for furnished space, against Rs. 60–70 per sq. ft. for companies and service providers. For a small space of 3–4 desks or a single shared room, this would likely be a meagre monthly cost in the low thousands, the exact figure to be confirmed once we speak with FITT directly.

If this does not work out for any reason, availability, cost, or timing, we simply do not pursue it, and it has no bearing on the cohort itself. We are not looking at any option outside campus. This stays a small exploratory item, not a line we are committing to in this proposal.

7. Legal Structure and Incorporation

7.1 Cohort 01 routing

For Cohort 01, all programme-level activity routes through your existing India-based partner entity rather than a new SInC or joint entity, avoiding early-stage registration delays on the programme side. This is unaffected by anything below: it is how the cohort itself operates, separate from whether an individual venture incorporates.

7.2 Incorporation timing follows the funding path, not a fixed date

Rather than one rule for every venture, incorporation timing depends on which funding path a venture is actually on. A SAFE has to be signed by an actual legal entity, not by individual founders personally, so any venture going down the SAFE path in Section 5 needs to incorporate before that document is executed. In practice, this means incorporating during screening or early in the cohort for ventures we already have confidence in, not waiting until Demo Day.

For ventures not on a SAFE during the cohort itself, where the more likely path is raising directly at Demo Day against a future cheque (a structure several comparable Indian student-investment programmes follow, writing a single cheque for a defined equity stake once the venture is more clearly formed), incorporation can reasonably happen later, at the point that round is actually being closed.

7.3 Cost and who pays first

Incorporation cost is folded into the same per-venture reimbursement cap as build costs in Section 6.1, rather than negotiated separately. A founder may need to pay the incorporation fee out of pocket first, since the entity has to exist before any reimbursement structure can run through it; this is then reimbursed in that month’s cycle the same way any other build cost is, not treated as a separate, unbudgeted expense.

7.4 Where this is left open

The exact point at which a venture not yet on a clear funding path should be told to incorporate is genuinely a judgment call, depending more on your read of a team’s readiness than on a fixed process rule. We propose leaving this to your discretion case by case, rather than forcing it into a date that may not fit every venture.

8. Rules of Engagement

In your words: the rules should be clear for everybody, agreed before we start, so that this is, in effect, a handshake and a letter of intent rather than something negotiated as we go. This is our proposed first draft of those rules, deliberately two-sided: what teams and SInC commit to, and what we are asking you to commit to in return. Where something genuinely depends on your judgment as the cheque writer, we say so directly rather than pretending it can be fixed on paper.

8.1 Ownership and IP, from day one

Every student joining the cohort signs an IP assignment to their own venture, not to SInC and not to the investing partner. This follows the standard most established accelerators operate on: the founders own the company and the IP they build; the accelerator's role is investment and support, not ownership. The only exception is where a venture is built on IP explicitly sourced by you or your network (Tracks 1 and 2, Section 3); in that case the licensing or ownership split is agreed in writing before the team starts work on it, not after.

8.2 The three boundary conditions

Three boundaries are set for every venture at cohort entry. Each has a default that applies unless an exception is explicitly agreed in advance.

Boundary	Default, with named exception
Money	Build costs capped per Section 6.1, reimbursed against actual bills. Exception: any venture with a structurally different capital need requests a higher cap in week one, agreed before spend is incurred, not after.
Cap table	Stage 0 instrument and pre-seed option terms per Section 5 apply uniformly. Exception: a venture with an unusual capital requirement (e.g. requiring a larger round before Demo Day) is treated as its own case, scoped and agreed separately rather than forced into the standard structure.
Investment	Funding for each venture follows the proposal-and-evaluation process in Section 5.1, at the investor's discretion against the case made and progress shown; this discretion is the one boundary we are not proposing to fix in advance, since it is fundamentally a judgment call on team and opportunity quality.

Any exception, on any of the three, is requested by the team and agreed jointly by SInC and you before it takes effect. Exceptions are not negotiated mid-cohort once work has started; this is the one rule we think should not bend.

8.3 Performance gates: three outcomes, not one

Section 4 sets what satisfactory progress looks like at each monthly gate. Here we make the consequence of that assessment explicit, since a first cohort built as a playground should give a struggling team room to recover rather than a single pass-or-fail moment. At each gate, a team falls into one of three outcomes:

Outcome	What happens next
On track	Continues as normal, free to bring a funding proposal forward per Section 5.1 when ready.
Behind, but engaged	Continues, with a defined check-in plan agreed jointly by the team and their SInC coordinator for the next gate; not flagged as a strike against the team, simply a course-correction.
Disengaged	Only triggered by missing the reporting floor (Section 4) without communication, not by weak progress alone. Leads to removal from the cohort.

This means weak progress on its own is never grounds for removal in Cohort 01; only disengagement is. We think this is the right calibration for a first, exploratory cohort, and are open to a stricter structure if you would prefer one.

8.4 Disagreement and departure

Disagreement within a founding team is first addressed by the assigned SInC coordinator, escalated jointly to SInC and you if unresolved, before any external step is taken. Every venture has a simple vesting agreement and an exit agreement in place from the start: if a founder leaves voluntarily before the cohort ends, for reasons other than underperformance, unvested equity is forfeited back to the venture rather than retained in full. We propose this stay simple for Cohort 01, full forfeiture on early voluntary exit rather than a graded schedule, since three months is too short for a meaningful multi-year vesting curve to matter.

8.5 Mid-cohort joiners

A student joining an existing venture mid-cohort as a co-creator receives no additional perks under the structures above, including the founder fellowship in 6.4, but may continue with the team and is covered by the same IP assignment in 8.1. If a venture brings someone in as paid help rather than a co-founder, for instance hiring an employee, that payment comes from the venture's own investment or revenue, not from the SInC-administered monthly reimbursement budget in Section 6.1, which is scoped for build costs, not salaries.

8.6 What happens to ventures not selected for further investment

A venture that does not receive Stage 0 capital or a pre-seed cheque at the end of the cohort retains full rights to its work and its entity (per Section 7) and is free to raise from any other investor with no restriction or right of first refusal attached, including against any SAFE already in place from earlier in the cohort. Incorporation support, if used, is available regardless of investment outcome. This is a deliberate choice: the goal of the cohort, per your own framing, is real ventures created, not a small number of winners extracted from a larger pool that loses everything else.

8.7 A few things from your side

Rules of engagement work best when they go both ways. A few small things from your side would make the structure above easier for everyone to plan around, none of which touch your overall time commitment, which we are happy to leave to direct conversation as in Section 9.

- **A general sense of timing on decisions:** where a venture is waiting on a funding or top-up decision, even a rough sense of when to expect a response helps SInC plan the gate cycle around it.
- **Stability on agreed terms:** once a venture's boundaries in Section 8.2 are set, we would hope these stay steady rather than shift mid-cohort, outside the joint exception process described above.
- **One clear point of contact:** whether funding or exception decisions route through you directly or through your partner entity, knowing this upfront avoids confusion later.

9. What This Proposal Does Not Cover

A few items are deliberately left out of this document and either reserved for direct discussion or left to good faith rather than fixed on paper. Your personal time commitment and format of involvement each month, and the specifics of mentor sourcing from your network, are both better settled in conversation than written here at this stage. Separately, where a cohort venture goes on to raise a further round, gets covered in press, or reaches another public milestone after Cohort 01, we would simply ask that SInC and the cohort be acknowledged as part of that story. This isn't something we're proposing as a contractual term, just a fair and reasonable expectation given the role the cohort played, and one we'd hope any founder would be glad to extend.

10. Next Step

If this is broadly fair from your side, we propose treating this as the working framework for Cohort 01, in the spirit of the handshake and letter of intent discussed. We are ready to begin selection publicity as soon as we are aligned, with the MoU process running in parallel through your partner entity.